

Admin Dashboard — Backend Requirements

What the dashboard does today, and the external services it needs before the shop can run on it day to day.

Prepared for: Iqballaz Customs **Date:** 5 August 2026 **Status:** Front end complete, sample data

1. Where things stand

The admin dashboard is **fully built and clickable**. Every screen from the approved reference design exists and works: the dashboard overview with revenue chart and figures, an appointments calendar with month, week and day views, and thirteen management screens covering customers, vehicles, projects, services, invoices, payments, finance, reviews, messages, users, staff, inventory and an activity log. You can add, edit and delete records, search, sort, filter and page through them, and book or reschedule from the calendar.

What it is **not** doing yet is remembering anything. All of it currently runs on sample data held in the browser, so a page refresh resets it. Nothing is stored, no card is charged, and no customer is emailed or texted. That is by design — the interface was built first so it could be reviewed and signed off before the plumbing behind it is commissioned.

Making it real means connecting a small number of external services. This document lists each one: what it is for, what it costs, and what we need from you to set it up.

What works today vs. what needs a service

AREA	TODAY	NEEDS
All screens, layout, navigation, mobile	Complete and working	NOTHING
Adding and editing records	Works, but resets on refresh	DATABASE
Staff sign-in	One shared password	ACCOUNTS
Invoices and payments	Displayed only; nothing is charged	PAYMENTS
Appointment confirmations and reminders	Not sent	EMAIL / SMS
Website enquiries reaching the inbox	Accepted, but only logged	DATABASE
Customer reviews	Typed in by hand	REVIEWS SYNC
Invoice PDFs and build photos	Fixed files in the site folder	FILE STORAGE
+12% from last week figures	Sample numbers	REPORTING

2. Essential — the dashboard cannot go live without these

Phase 1. Everything else depends on this group.

2.1 Hosting

Where the website and dashboard actually run. The site is already built on a platform that hosts it directly, with automatic deployments, HTTPS and a global cache included.

RECOMMENDED	Vercel (built by the makers of the site's framework — least friction)
ALTERNATIVES	Netlify, Cloudflare Pages, or a self-managed server
INDICATIVE COST	Free tier is viable to start; approx. \$20/month per seat on the paid plan
WE NEED	An account in the shop's name, and the domain's DNS access to point <i>iqballazcustoms.com</i> at it

2.2 Database

The single most important item. This is the shop's permanent record: customers, vehicles, appointments, projects, invoices, payments, inventory and staff. Without it, nothing the dashboard shows survives a refresh.

It also becomes the one source of truth shared with the customer Vehicle Passport already on the public site, so a customer's warranty and service history stops being hand-maintained in two places.

RECOMMENDED	Supabase or Neon (both managed PostgreSQL, with automatic backups)
ALTERNATIVES	Vercel Postgres, Amazon RDS
INDICATIVE COST	Free tier covers early use; approx. \$19–25/month once past it
WE NEED	An account in the shop's name. Also a decision on where data is stored geographically, and how long records are kept
NOTE	Please budget for this even if usage stays inside a free tier — free tiers pause inactive databases, which is not appropriate for live business records

2.3 Staff accounts and permissions

Today the dashboard has a proper sign-in screen, but behind it sits a single shared password. That means no individual staff logins, no password resets, and no record of who changed what.

The Users and Staff screens already show access levels — Super Admin, Manager, Technician, Front Desk — but nothing enforces them yet. Once this is connected, those levels become real: a technician would not be able to see finance, for instance.

RECOMMENDED	Auth.js (no licence fee, runs on the shop's own hosting) or Clerk (paid, but includes ready-made password reset and two-factor)
INDICATIVE COST	Auth.js: free. Clerk: free to roughly 10,000 monthly users, then approx. \$25/month
WE NEED	The list of staff who should have access and the level each one gets. A decision on whether two-factor sign-in is required

Recommendation: commission Phase 1 as a single block. Hosting, database and accounts are interdependent, and splitting them means paying twice to wire the same connections.

3. Operating — needed for daily use

Phase 2. Turns the dashboard from a record book into the tool the shop runs on.

3.1 Card payments

The Invoices and Payments screens list what is owed and what has been settled, but nothing charges a card today. Connecting a payment provider lets an invoice be sent as a payment link, and marks itself paid automatically when the customer pays — no manual reconciliation.

RECOMMENDED	Stripe (already referenced on the public site's financing page)
ALTERNATIVES	Square, PayPal
INDICATIVE COST	No monthly fee. Roughly 2.9% + \$0.30 per card transaction — confirm current US rates at signup
WE NEED	A Stripe account with business verification completed, and the shop's bank details for payouts
NOTE	The existing financing partners (Acima, Snap) stay a separate manual process unless they provide a direct integration — worth asking them

3.2 Email and text messaging

For appointment confirmations, reminders the day before, and “your vehicle is ready” notices. Given the shop books by appointment with same-week slots, text messages will matter more than email for reducing no-shows.

RECOMMENDED	Resend or Postmark for email; Twilio for text messages
INDICATIVE COST	Email: free to roughly 3,000 messages/month, then approx. \$20/month . Text: approx. \$0.008 per message plus about \$1.15/month for a number — confirm current rates
WE NEED	Permission to send from the shop's domain (a small DNS change), the sending address to use, and approval of the message wording. US text messaging also requires business registration with the carriers, which takes a few days

3.3 Website enquiries into the dashboard

The quote form and chat assistant on the public site already collect enquiries correctly. At present they are only recorded in the server log. Pointing them at the database turns the Messages screen into the live inbox it already looks like.

REQUIRES	Nothing new — this is included once the database (2.2) exists
INDICATIVE COST	None
WE NEED	Confirmation of who should be notified when a new enquiry arrives

3.4 File storage

For invoice PDFs and customer build photographs. These currently point at fixed files in the website folder, which does not scale and cannot be added to from the dashboard. Proper storage also allows private links, so a customer's invoice is not publicly guessable.

RECOMMENDED	Cloudflare R2 (no charge for data transfer out) or Amazon S3
INDICATIVE COST	Typically under \$5/month at this scale
WE NEED	An account, and a decision on how long customer photos are retained

4. Enhancement — valuable, not urgent

Phase 3. Can follow once the shop is running on the dashboard.

4.1 Google review sync

The Reviews screen currently holds reviews typed in by hand. Connecting Google Business Profile pulls them in automatically, so the screen and the website's review section always reflect reality.

REQUIRES	Google Business Profile / Places API access
INDICATIVE COST	Charged per request; low volume typically sits within the monthly free allowance — confirm current terms
WE NEED	Admin access to the shop's Google Business Profile

4.2 Reporting figures

The comparison figures on the dashboard — “+12% from last week”, “+15% revenue” — are sample numbers. Once real records accumulate, these become genuine period-on-period calculations from the shop's own data.

REQUIRES	Nothing new — calculated from the database (2.2)
INDICATIVE COST	None
WE NEED	Confirmation of which figures matter most to the business, so the right ones are shown

4.3 Editable settings

The Settings screen currently displays business details, opening hours and the live promotion, but they are read-only — those values live in the website's code, and showing editable boxes would imply a save that goes nowhere. Once stored in the database, the shop can change opening hours or swap the promotion without a developer.

REQUIRES	Nothing new — depends on the database (2.2)
INDICATIVE COST	None

5. Indicative running costs

Monthly, at the shop's expected volume. Figures are indicative and should be confirmed at signup — providers change pricing, and several offer free tiers that may cover early use.

SERVICE	PURPOSE	PHASE	INDICATIVE / MONTH
Hosting	Runs the site and dashboard	1	\$0 – 20
Database	Stores every record	1	\$0 – 25
Staff accounts	Individual logins and permissions	1	\$0 – 25
Card payments	Charging and reconciling invoices	2	Per transaction
Email	Confirmations and receipts	2	\$0 – 20
Text messaging	Appointment reminders	2	\$5 – 20
File storage	Invoice PDFs, build photos	2	Under \$5
Review sync	Google reviews	3	\$0 – 5
Typical total, excluding card transaction fees			Roughly \$5 – 120

The lower end reflects starting on free tiers; the upper end reflects paid plans across every service. Card processing is charged as a percentage of takings rather than a monthly fee, so it scales with revenue rather than adding fixed cost.

6. What we need from you

Work can begin as soon as these are available. Accounts should be created in the shop's name, not a developer's, so ownership stays with the business.

Accounts to open

- Hosting platform (Phase 1)
- Database provider (Phase 1)
- Stripe, with business verification and bank details (Phase 2)
- Email and text messaging providers (Phase 2)
- File storage provider (Phase 2)

Access to grant

- DNS access for *iqballazcustoms.com*, to point the domain and to authorise sending email from it
- Admin access to the Google Business Profile, for review sync (Phase 3)

Decisions to confirm

- Which staff get dashboard access, and at what level
- Whether two-factor sign-in is required for staff

- Wording for appointment confirmations and reminders
- How long customer records and photographs are retained
- Who is notified when a new website enquiry arrives

Information to verify

The dashboard is currently populated with realistic sample data so the screens could be reviewed properly. The following are placeholders and must be replaced with real figures before launch:

- Staff names and roles
- Service pricing and typical duration
- Inventory items, suppliers and reorder levels
- The finance ledger and all revenue figures

On the sample data: none of the customers, vehicles, invoices or payments currently shown are real. They exist purely to make the screens legible during review and will be cleared before the shop starts using the dashboard.

7. Suggested sequence

PHASE	DELIVERS	OUTCOME FOR THE SHOP
1	Hosting, database, staff accounts	The dashboard becomes real: records are kept, staff have their own logins, and the customer Vehicle Passport shares the same data
2	Payments, email and text, enquiries inbox, file storage	The shop can run its day on it: take payment, confirm and remind customers, and handle enquiries in one place
3	Review sync, reporting, editable settings	Reviews stay current without typing, figures reflect real trading, and the shop can update its own details

Phase 1 is the meaningful milestone — at the end of it the dashboard stops being a demonstration and becomes the shop's system of record. Phases 2 and 3 add capability on top of a working foundation and can be scheduled to suit budget.